

CHAPTER 6: BETWEEN ADVENTURES

A CAMPAIGN IS MUCH MORE THAN A SERIES OF adventures. It also includes the moments between them—the various distractions and side pursuits that engage the characters when they're not exploring the wilderness, plundering dungeons, and gallivanting around the multiverse on some epic quest.

The natural pace of a campaign offers lulls between adventures, time for the characters to spend their treasure and pursue their goals. This downtime gives the characters an opportunity to sink their roots a little deeper into the world, building a personal investment in what happens to the people and places around them, which can, in turn, draw them into further adventures.

Chapter 5, "Equipment," of the *Player's Handbook* details the expenses that a character incurs for basic necessities, depending on the lifestyle the character chooses, from poverty to luxury. Chapter 8, "Adventuring," of that book describes some of the downtime activities they can pursue between adventures. This chapter fills in the gaps, describing the expenses of owning property and hiring NPCs, and a variety of additional downtime activities characters can pursue. The beginning of the chapter also offers suggestions for linking adventures together and keeping track of events in your campaign.

LINKING ADVENTURES

A campaign in the style of an episodic television show rarely needs story links between its adventures. Each adventure features its own villains, and once the characters complete the adventure, there are typically no loose plot threads. The next adventure presents an altogether different challenge having nothing to do with the adventure that preceded it. As the characters gain experience points, they become more powerful, as do the threats they must overcome. This kind of campaign is easy to run, since it requires little effort beyond finding or creating adventures appropriate for the party's level.

A campaign with a narrative lets the players feel as though their actions have far-reaching consequences. They're not just racking up experience points. A few simple modifications can help you overlay overarching elements to create a serialized campaign in which early adventures help set up later ones.

USING AN OVERARCHING STORY

This section presents a couple of examples of overarching stories which have, over the years, fueled many classic D&D campaigns.

The adventurers' goal in the first example is to amass the power they need to defeat a powerful enemy that threatens the world. Their goal in the second example is to defend something they care about by destroying whatever threatens it. The two examples are, in effect, the same story (variations of the battle between good and evil) told in different ways.

EXAMPLE 1: THE QUEST OF MANY PARTS

You can tie adventures together using an overarching goal that can be fulfilled only by first completing a series of related quests. For example, you could create a villain who can't be defeated until the characters explore nine dungeons in which the Nine Dread Princes reside, with each of these dungeons stocked with enough monsters and hazards to advance the adventurers two or three levels. The adventurers spend their whole careers fighting the Nine Dread Princes before finally pursuing an epic quest to destroy the princes' monstrous progenitor. As long as every dungeon is unique and interesting, your players will appreciate the tight focus of the campaign.

In a similar type of quest campaign, the adventurers might need to collect fragments of an artifact that are scattered in ruins across the multiverse, before reassembling the artifact and using it to defeat a cosmic threat.

EXAMPLE 2: AGENTS OF X

You can also build a campaign around the idea that the adventurers are agents of something larger than themselves—a kingdom or secret organization, for example. Wherever their allegiance lies, the adventurers are motivated by loyalty and the goal of protecting whatever it is they serve.

The characters' overarching mission might be to explore and map an uncharted region, forging alliances where they can and overcoming threats they encounter along the way. Their goal might be to find the ancient capital of a fallen empire, which lies beyond the realm of a known enemy and forces them to navigate hostile territory. The characters could be pilgrims in search of a holy site or members of a secret order dedicated to defending the last bastions of civilization in an ever-declining world. Or they might be spies and assassins, striving to weaken an enemy country by targeting its evil leaders and plundering its treasures.

PLANTING ADVENTURE SEEDS

You can make a campaign feel like one story with many chapters by planting the seeds of the next adventure before the current one is finished. This technique can naturally move the characters along to their next goal.

If you've planted a seed well, the characters have something else to do when they finish an adventure. Perhaps a character drinks from a magic fountain in a dungeon and receives a mystifying vision that leads to the next quest. The party might find a cryptic map or relic that, once its meaning or purpose is determined, points to a new destination. Perhaps an NPC warns the characters of impending danger or implores them for help.

The trick is to not distract the characters from the adventure at hand. Designing an effective hook for a future adventure requires finesse. The lure should be compelling, but not so irresistible that the players stop caring about what their characters are doing right now.

To keep players from straying, save your best ideas for the very end of your adventures, or insert them during periods of downtime.

Here are a few examples of ways in which an adventure seed can be revealed:

- On a villain's corpse, the characters find evidence that the villain was working for someone else.
- A captured NPC reveals the location of someone or something that might interest the characters.
- The characters are heading to a local tavern when they spot a wanted poster or a missing person poster (complete with the promise of a sizable reward).
- Members of the local militia or city watch put out the word that a crime has been committed, and they're looking for potential witnesses and suspects.
- The characters receive an anonymous letter that sheds light on a plot or impending event of which they were previously unaware.

FORESHADOWING

Foreshadowing is an exercise in subtlety, involving the delicate planting of seeds for future adventures. Not all foreshadowing bears fruit, particularly if the clues are too subtle or if events conspire to take your campaign in a new direction. The goal of foreshadowing is to hint at upcoming events and new threats in your campaign without making it obvious to players that you're telling them what the future holds. Here are a few examples:

- An object worn or carried by an enemy has the symbol of a previously unknown organization engraved or written on it.
- A mad woman standing on a street corner spouts fragments of an ancient prophecy, while pointing a crooked finger at the characters.
- The king and queen announce the marriage of their son to the daughter of a neighboring monarch, but various factions oppose the union. Trouble is brewing.
- Bugbear scouts are making incursions into civilized lands and spying on settlements, as a prelude to a hobgoblin warlord's invasion.
- A puppet show in a market square predicts a tragic outcome if two noble houses on the cusp of declaring war on each other refuse to reconcile.
- NPC adventurers in a city are being murdered in a similar yet unusual manner, hinting at a future threat to the player characters.

CAMPAIGN TRACKING

Consistent details bring your campaign to life, and continuity helps players imagine that their characters are living in a real world. If the adventurers frequent a particular tavern, the staff, layout of the building, and decor shouldn't change much from one visit to the next. That said, changes can occur as a result of the characters' actions or of actions they learn about. When the adventurers kill a monster, it stays dead, unless someone raises it. When they remove treasure from a room, it doesn't reappear the next time they enter—assuming it hasn't been stolen from them! If they leave a door open, it should stay open until someone closes it.

No one's memory is infallible, so it pays to keep records. Jot notes directly on an adventure map to keep track of open doors, disarmed traps, and the like. Events beyond the scope of a single adventure are best recorded in a notebook dedicated to your campaign. Whether it's a physical book or an electronic file, such a record is a great way to keep your notes organized.

Your notebook might include any of the following elements.

Campaign Planner. Write down the main story arc of your campaign, and keep track of things that you hope appear in future adventures. Update it as the campaign develops, adding ideas as they come to you.

Character Notes. Write down the characters' backgrounds and goals, since these notes can help you design adventure content that provides opportunities for character development.

Keep a running tally of the adventurers' classes and levels, as well as any quests and downtime activities they're engaged in.

If the characters have a ship or stronghold, record its name and whereabouts, as well as any hirelings in the characters' employ.

Player Handouts. Keep a copy of all handouts you make for your players so that you don't have to remember their contents later.

Adventure Log. Think of this log as an episode guide for your campaign. Summarize each game session or adventure to help you keep track of the unfolding campaign story. You can give your players access to this log as well, or to an edited version stripped of your notes and secrets. (The players might also keep their own record of adventures, which you can refer to if your own log is incomplete.)

NPC Notes. Record statistics and roleplaying notes for any NPC the characters interact with more than once. For example, your notes might differentiate important people in a town by their different voices, as well as their names, the places where they live and work, the names of their family members and associates, and maybe even a secret that each one of them has.

Campaign Calendar. Your world feels more real to your players when the characters notice the passage of time. Note details such as the change of seasons and major holidays, and keep track of any important events that affect the larger story.

Toolbox. Keep notes whenever you create or significantly alter a monster, magic item, or trap. Keep any maps, random dungeons, or encounters you create. This information ensures you won't repeat your work, and you'll be able to draw on this material later.

RECURRING EXPENSES

Besides the expenses associated with maintaining a particular lifestyle, adventurers might have additional drains on their adventuring income. Player characters who come into possession of property, own businesses, and employ hirelings must cover the expenses that accompany these ventures.

MAINTENANCE COSTS

Property	Total Cost per Day	Skilled Hirelings	Untrained Hirelings
Abbey	20 gp	5	25
Farm	5 sp	1	2
Guildhall, town or city	5 gp	5	3
Inn, rural roadside	10 gp	5	10
Inn, town or city	5 gp	1	5
Keep or small castle	100 gp	50	50
Lodge, hunting	5 sp	1	—
Noble estate	10 gp	3	15
Outpost or fort	50 gp	20	40
Palace or large castle	400 gp	200	100
Shop	2 gp	1	—
Temple, large	25 gp	10	10
Temple, small	1 gp	2	—
Tower, fortified	25 gp	10	—
Trading post	10 gp	4	2

It's not unusual for adventurers—especially after 10th level—to gain possession of a castle, a tavern, or another piece of property. They might buy it with their hard-won loot, take it by force, obtain it in a lucky draw from a *deck of many things*, or acquire it by other means.

The Maintenance Costs table shows the per-day upkeep cost for any such property. (The cost of a normal residence isn't included here because it falls under lifestyle expenses, as discussed in the *Player's Handbook*.) Maintenance expenses need to be paid every 30 days. Given that adventurers spend much of their time adventuring, staff includes a steward who can make payments in the party's absence.

Total Cost per Day. The cost includes everything it takes to maintain the property and keep things running smoothly, including the salaries of hirelings. If the property earns money that can offset maintenance costs (by charging fees, collecting tithes or donations, or selling goods), that is taken into account in the table.

Skilled and Untrained Hirelings. The *Player's Handbook* explains the difference between a skilled hireling and an untrained one.

BUSINESSES

An adventurer-owned business can earn enough money to cover its own maintenance costs. However, the owner needs to periodically ensure that everything is running smoothly by tending to the business between adventures. See the information on running a business in the "Downtime Activities" section of this chapter.

GARRISONS

Castles and keeps employ soldiers (use the veteran and guard statistics in the *Monster Manual*) to defend them. Roadside inns, outposts and forts, palaces, and temples rely on less-experienced defenders (use the guard statistics in the *Monster Manual*). These armed warriors make up the bulk of a property's skilled hirelings.



DOWNTIME ACTIVITIES

The campaign benefits when characters have time between adventures to engage in other activities. Allowing days, weeks, or months to pass between adventures stretches the campaign over a longer period of time and helps to manage the characters' level progression, preventing them from gaining too much power too quickly.

Allowing characters to pursue side interests between adventures also encourages players to become more invested in the campaign world. When a character owns a tavern in a village or spends time carousing with the locals, that character's player is more likely to respond to threats to the village and its inhabitants.

As your campaign progresses, your players' characters will not only become more powerful but also more influential and invested in the world. They might be inclined to undertake projects that require more time between adventures, such as building and maintaining a stronghold. As the party gains levels, you can add more downtime between adventures to give characters the time they need to pursue such interests. Whereas days or weeks might pass between low-level adventures, the amount of downtime between higher-level adventures might be measured in months or years.

MORE DOWNTIME ACTIVITIES

Chapter 8, "Adventuring," of the *Player's Handbook* describes a few downtime activities to fill the void between adventures. Depending on the style of your campaign and the particular backgrounds and interests of the adventurers, you can make some or all of the following additional activities available as options.

BUILDING A STRONGHOLD

A character can spend time between adventures building a stronghold. Before work can begin, the character must acquire a plot of land. If the estate lies within a kingdom or similar domain, the character will need a royal charter (a legal document granting permission to oversee the estate in the name of the crown), a land grant (a legal document bequeathing custody of the land to the character for as long as he or she remains loyal to the crown), or a deed (a legal document that serves as proof of ownership). Land can also be acquired by inheritance or other means.

Royal charters and land grants are usually given by the crown as a reward for faithful service, although they can also be bought. Deeds can be bought or inherited. A small estate might sell for as little as 100 gp or as much as 1,000 gp. A large estate might cost 5,000 gp or more, if it can be bought at all.

Once the estate is secured, a character needs access to building materials and laborers. The Building a Stronghold table shows the cost of building the stronghold (including materials and labor) and the amount of time it takes, provided that the character is using downtime to oversee construction. Work can continue while the character is away, but each day the character is away adds 3 days to the construction time.

BUILDING A STRONGHOLD

Stronghold	Construction Cost	Construction Time
Abbey	50,000 gp	400 days
Guildhall, town or city	5,000 gp	60 days
Keep or small castle	50,000 gp	400 days
Noble estate with manor	25,000 gp	150 days
Outpost or fort	15,000 gp	100 days
Palace or large castle	500,000 gp	1,200 days
Temple	50,000 gp	400 days
Tower, fortified	15,000 gp	100 days
Trading post	5,000 gp	60 days

CAROUSING

Characters can spend their downtime engaged in a variety of hedonistic activities such as attending parties, binge drinking, gambling, or anything else that helps them cope with the perils they face on their adventures.

A carousing character spends money as though maintaining a wealthy lifestyle (see chapter 5, "Equipment," of the *Player's Handbook*). At the end of the period spent carousing, the player rolls percentile dice and adds the character's level, then compares the total to the Carousing table to determine what happens to the character, or you choose.

CAROUSING

d100 + Level Result

01–10	You are jailed for 1d4 days at the end of the downtime period on charges of disorderly conduct and disturbing the peace. You can pay a fine of 10 gp to avoid jail time, or you can try to resist arrest.
11–20	You regain consciousness in a strange place with no memory of how you got there, and you have been robbed of $3d6 \times 5$ gp.
21–30	You make an enemy. This person, business, or organization is now hostile to you. The DM determines the offended party. You decide how you offended them.
31–40	You are caught up in a whirlwind romance. Roll a d20. On a 1–5, the romance ends badly. On a 6–10, the romance ends amicably. On an 11–20, the romance is ongoing. You determine the identity of the love interest, subject to your DM's approval. If the romance ends badly, you might gain a new flaw. If it ends well or is ongoing, your new love interest might represent a new bond.
41–80	You earn modest winnings from gambling and recuperate your lifestyle expenses for the time spent carousing.
81–90	You earn modest winnings from gambling. You recuperate your lifestyle expenses for the time spent carousing and gain $1d20 \times 4$ gp.
91 or higher	You make a small fortune gambling. You recuperate your lifestyle expenses for the time spent carousing and gain $4d6 \times 10$ gp. Your carousing becomes the stuff of local legend.

CRAFTING A MAGIC ITEM

Magic items are the DM's purview, so you decide how they fall into the party's possession. As an option, you can allow player characters to craft magic items.

The creation of a magic item is a lengthy, expensive task. To start, a character must have a formula that describes the construction of the item. The character must also be a spellcaster with spell slots and must be able to cast any spells that the item can produce. Moreover, the character must meet a level minimum determined by the item's rarity, as shown in the Crafting Magic Items table. For example, a 3rd-level character could create a *wand of magic missiles* (an uncommon item), as long as the character has spell slots and can



cast *magic missile*. That same character could make a *+1 weapon* (another uncommon item), no particular spell required.

You can decide that certain items also require special materials or locations to be created. For example, a character might need alchemist's supplies to brew a particular potion, or the formula for a *flame tongue* might require that the weapon be forged with lava.

CRAFTING MAGIC ITEMS

Item Rarity	Creation Cost	Minimum Level
Common	100 gp	3rd
Uncommon	500 gp	3rd
Rare	5,000 gp	6th
Very rare	50,000 gp	11th
Legendary	500,000 gp	17th

An item has a creation cost specified in the Crafting Magic Items table. A character engaged in the crafting of a magic item makes progress in 25 gp increments, spending that amount for each day of work until the total cost is paid. The character is assumed to work for 8 hours each of those days. Thus, creating an uncommon magic item takes 20 days and 500 gp. You are free to adjust the costs to better suit your campaign.

If a spell will be produced by the item being created, the creator must expend one spell slot of the spell's level for each day of the creation process. The spell's material components must also be at hand throughout the process. If the spell normally consumes those components, they are consumed by the creation process. If the item will be able to produce the spell only once, as with a *spell scroll*, the components are consumed only once by the process. Otherwise, the components are consumed once each day of the item's creation.

Multiple characters can combine their efforts to create a magic item if each of them meets the level prerequisite. Each character can contribute spells, spell slots, and components, as long as everyone participates during the entire crafting process. Each character can contribute 25 gp worth of effort for each day spent helping to craft the item.

Normally, a character who undertakes this activity creates a magic item described in chapter 7, "Treasure." At your discretion, you can allow players to design their own magic items, using the guidelines in chapter 9, "Dungeon Master's Workshop."

While crafting a magic item, a character can maintain a modest lifestyle without having to pay the 1 gp per day, or a comfortable lifestyle at half the normal cost (see chapter 5, "Equipment," of the *Player's Handbook*).

GAINING RENOWN

A character can spend downtime improving his or her renown within a particular organization (see "Renown" in chapter 1). Between adventures, a character undertakes minor tasks for the organization and socializes with its members. After pursuing these activities for a combined number of days equal to his or her current renown multiplied by 10, the character's renown increases by 1.

PERFORMING SACRED RITES

A pious character can spend time between adventures performing sacred rites in a temple affiliated with a god he or she reveres. Between rites, the character spends time in meditation and prayer.

A character who is a priest in the temple can lead these rites, which might include weddings, funerals, and ordinations. A layperson can offer sacrifices in a temple or assist a priest with a rite.

A character who spends at least 10 days performing sacred rites gains inspiration (described in chapter 4 of the *Player's Handbook*) at the start of each day for the next 2d6 days.

RUNNING A BUSINESS

Adventurers can end up owning businesses that have nothing to do with delving into dungeons or saving the world. A character might inherit a smithy, or the party might be given a parcel of farmland or a tavern as a reward. If they hold on to the business, they might feel obliged to spend time between adventures maintaining the venture and making sure it runs smoothly.

A character rolls percentile dice and adds the number of days spent on this downtime activity (maximum 30), then compares the total to the Running a Business table to determine what happens.

If the character is required to pay a cost as a result of rolling on this table but fails to do so, the business begins to fail. For each unpaid debt incurred in this manner, the character takes a -10 penalty to subsequent rolls made on this table.

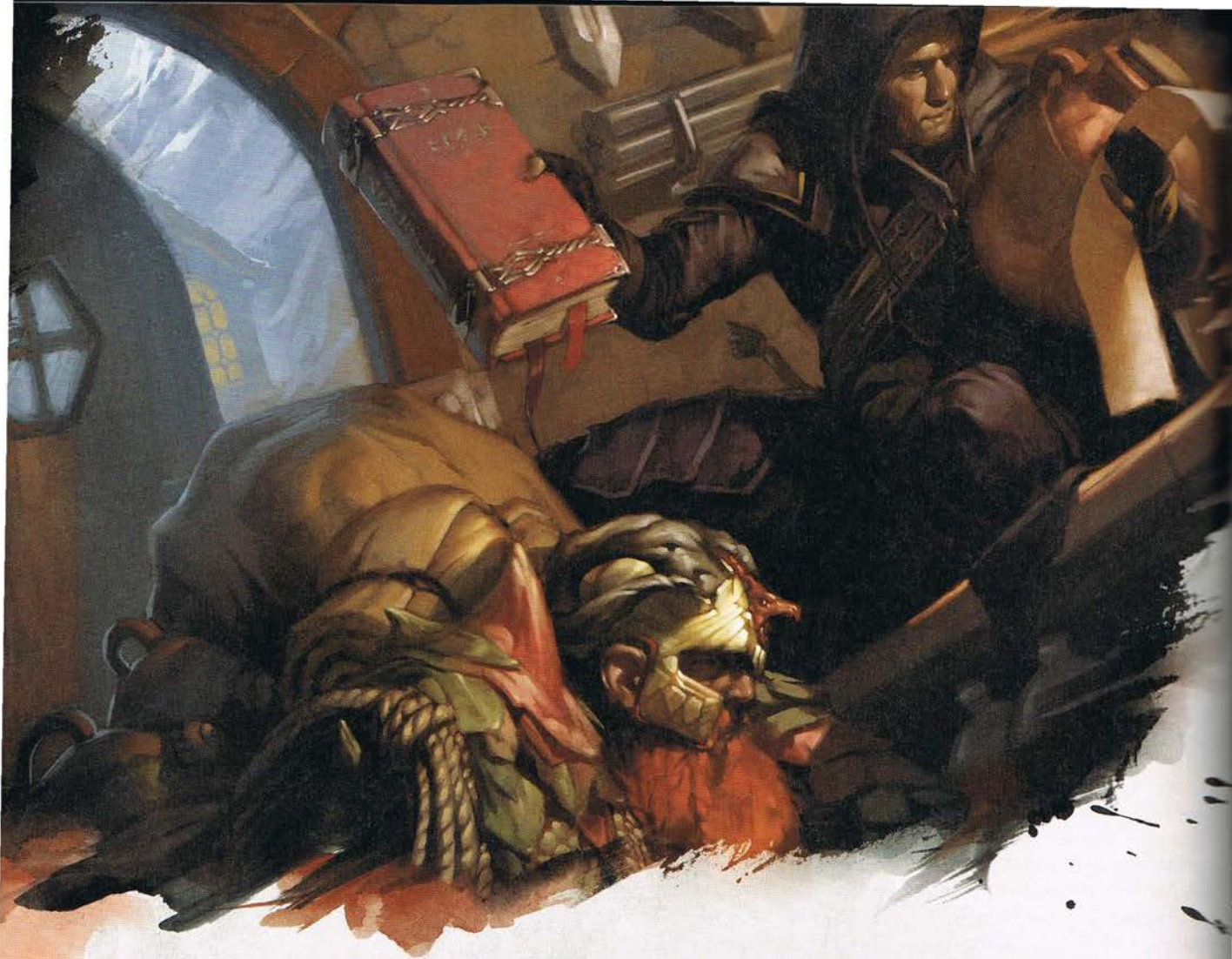
RUNNING A BUSINESS

d100 + Days	Result
01–20	You must pay one and a half times the business's maintenance cost for each of the days.
21–30	You must pay the business's full maintenance cost for each of the days.
31–40	You must pay half the business's maintenance cost for each of the days. Profits cover the other half.
41–60	The business covers its own maintenance cost for each of the days.
61–80	The business covers its own maintenance cost for each of the days. It earns a profit of 1d6 × 5 gp.
81–90	The business covers its own maintenance cost for each of the days. It earns a profit of 2d8 × 5 gp.
91 or higher	The business covers its own maintenance cost for each of the days. It earns a profit of 3d10 × 5 gp.

SELLING MAGIC ITEMS

Few people can afford to buy a magic item, and fewer still know how to find one. Adventurers are exceptional in this regard due to the nature of their profession.

A character who comes into possession of a common, uncommon, rare, or very rare magic item that he or she wants to sell can spend downtime searching for a buyer. This downtime activity can be performed only in a city or another location where one can find wealthy



individuals interested in buying magic items. Legendary magic items and priceless artifacts can't be sold during downtime. Finding someone to buy such an item can be the substance of an adventure or quest.

For each salable item, the character makes a DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check to find buyers. Another character can use his or her downtime to assist with the search, granting advantage on the checks. On a failed check, no buyer for the item is found after a search that lasts 10 days. On a successful check, a buyer for the item is found after a number of days based on the item's rarity, as shown in the Salable Magic Item table.

A character can attempt to find buyers for multiple magic items at once. Although this requires multiple Intelligence (Investigation) checks, the searches are occurring simultaneously, and the results of multiple failures or successes aren't added together. For example, if the character finds a buyer for a common magic item in 2 days and a buyer for an uncommon item in 5 days, but fails to find a buyer for a rare item up for grabs, the entire search takes 10 days.

For each item a character wishes to sell, the player rolls percentile dice and consults the Selling a Magic Item table, applying a modifier based on the item's rarity, as shown in the Salable Magic Items table. The character also makes a Charisma (Persuasion) check and adds that check's total to the roll. The subsequent total determines what a buyer offers to pay for the item.

You determine a buyer's identity. Buyers sometimes procure rare and very rare items through proxies to ensure that their identities remain unknown. If the buyer is shady, it's up to you whether the sale creates legal complications for the party later.

SALABLE MAGIC ITEMS

Rarity	Base Price	Days to Find Buyer	d100 Roll Modifier*
Common	100 gp	1d4	+10
Uncommon	500 gp	1d6	+0
Rare	5,000 gp	1d8	-10
Very rare	50,000 gp	1d10	-20

* Apply this modifier to rolls on the Selling a Magic Item table.

SELLING A MAGIC ITEM

d100 + Mod. You Find ...

20 or lower	A buyer offering a tenth of the base price
21–40	A buyer offering a quarter of the base price, and a shady buyer offering half the base price
41–80	A buyer offering half the base price, and a shady buyer offering the full base price
81–90	A buyer offering the full base price
91 or higher	A shady buyer offering one and a half times the base price, no questions asked

SOWING RUMORS

Swaying public opinion can be an effective way to bring down a villain or elevate a friend. Spreading rumors is an efficient, if underhanded, way to accomplish that goal. Well-placed rumors can increase the subject's standing in a community or embroil someone in scandal. A rumor needs to be simple, concrete, and hard to disprove. An effective rumor also has to be believable, playing off what people want to believe about the person in question.

Sowing a rumor about an individual or organization requires a number of days depending on the size of the community, as shown in the Sowing Rumors table. In a town or city, the time spent must be continuous. If the character spreads a rumor for ten days, disappears on an adventure for another few days and then returns, the rumor fades away without the benefit of constant repetition.

SOWING RUMORS

Settlement Size	Time Required
Village	2d6 days
Town	4d6 days
City	6d6 days

The character must spend 1 gp per day to cover the cost of drinks, social appearances, and the like. At the end of the time spent sowing the rumor, the character must make a DC 15 Charisma (Deception or Persuasion) check. If the check succeeds, the community's prevailing attitude toward the subject shifts one step toward friendly or hostile, as the character wishes. If the check fails, the rumor gains no traction, and further attempts to propagate it fail.

Shifting a community's general attitude toward a person or organization doesn't affect everyone in the community. Individuals might hold to their own opinions, particularly if they have personal experience in dealing with the subject of the rumors.

TRAINING TO GAIN LEVELS

As a variant rule, you can require characters to spend downtime training or studying before they gain the benefits of a new level. If you choose this option, once a character has earned enough experience points to attain a new level, he or she must train for a number of days before gaining any class features associated with the new level.

The training time required depends on the level to be gained, as shown on the Training to Gain Levels table. The training cost is for the total training time.

TRAINING TO GAIN LEVELS

Level Attained	Training Time	Training Cost
2nd–4th	10 days	20 gp
5th–10th	20 days	40 gp
11th–16th	30 days	60 gp
17th–20th	40 days	80 gp

CREATING DOWNTIME ACTIVITIES

Your players might be interested in pursuing downtime activities that aren't covered in this chapter or in the *Player's Handbook*. If you invent new downtime activities, remember the following:

- An activity should never negate the need or desire for characters to go on adventures.
- Activities that have a monetary cost associated with them provide opportunities for player characters to spend their hard-won treasure.
- Activities that reveal new adventure hooks and previously unknown facts about your campaign can help you foreshadow future events and conflicts.
- For an activity you expect a character to repeat with variable degrees of success, consider creating a random outcome table, modeled on the ones in this chapter.
- If a character belongs to a class or has a proficiency or background that would make him or her well suited to a particular activity, consider granting a bonus to ability checks made by the character to complete that activity successfully.



